

Alex E. Combs

Assistant Professor

University of Georgia · Athens, GA 30602

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Academic Appointments

Assistant Professor of Public Administration and Policy Department of Public Administration and Policy, University of Georgia	2020-Present
Visiting Assistant Professor Department of Public Administration and Policy, University of Georgia	2019-2020
Post-Doctoral Researcher & Instructor Martin School of Public Policy and Administration, University of Kentucky	2018-2019

Education

Ph.D. University of Kentucky (Public Policy & Administration)	2018
M.A. University of Kentucky (Public Administration)	2014
B.A. Eastern Kentucky University (Political Science)	2009

Research

Peer Reviewed Publications

- [11] Combs, A.E., Foster, J.M., & Troland, E. (2026). The Role of Property Assessment Oversight in School Finance Inequality. *National Tax Journal*. <https://doi.org/10.1086/742128>
- [10] Afonso, W., & Combs, A. (2026) “You keep using that word. I do not think it means what you think it means”: Interjurisdictional Equity in Local Option Tax Policy. *American Review of Public Administration*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/02750740261464894>
- [9] Combs, A. (2026). State Subsidy Reallocations and Postsecondary Institution Spending: Driving a Divergence in Education Quality and Amenities. *Research in Higher Education*, 67(4), 1-20. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11162-026-09899-1>
- [8] Afonso, W., & Combs, A. (2026). A Framework for Sales Tax Base Expansion: Food Taxation in North Carolina and Applications for Other States. *Public Budgeting & Finance* <http://doi.org/10.1111/pbaf.70017>
- [7] Combs, A.E. (2026) Beyond Access and Enrollment: How Distance Relates to Persistence and Degree Completion Among Students Attending In-State Public Institutions. *Journal of Postsecondary Student Success*, 5(2), 6-29. https://doi.org/10.33009/fsop_jpss139199
- [6] Combs, A., & Kim, S. (2026). Constraints and Contributions: The Effects of Tax Limits on Education-Supporting Nonprofit Revenue. *Public Finance Review*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/10911421251385050>

- [5] Combs, A.E., & Afonso, W. (2025). Dollars, Desks, and Development: The Impact of Local Sales Tax Revenue Redistribution on Recipient Programs in North Carolina. *National Tax Journal*, 78(2), 295-326. <https://doi.org/10.1086/733594>
- [4] Afonso, W., Combs, A., & Buerger, C. (2024). Plugging the Tax Leak: An Analysis of North Carolina's Local Sales Tax Redistribution Policy. *State and Local Government Review*, 56(1), 76-90. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0160323X231215057>
- [3] Combs, A.E. (2023). High School Student Achievement and College Enrollment in the Absence of School Improvement Interventions: Evidence from Kentucky. *Public Finance and Management*, 22(1). <https://doi.org/37.808/pfm.22.1.4>
- [2] Combs, A.E., & Foster, J.M. (2021). The Effects of Homestead Exemptions for Seniors and Disabled People on School Districts. *American Education Research Association Open*, 7. <https://doi.org/10.1177%2F2332858420988712>
- [1] Combs, A., Foster, J.M., & Toma E.F. (2018). Local Response to School Finance Equalization: Wealth or Place? *Public Finance and Management*, 18(3). <https://doi.org/10.1177/152397211801800301>

Works In Progress

- [5] Combs, A., & Afonso, W. Sharing the Burden: Did Sales Tax Redistribution Alleviate Excess Property Taxes in North Carolina Counties?
Under review, *Journal of Urban Affairs*
- [4] Park, H., Combs, A., Kim, S., & Jung, J. The Influence of Special Districts on Local Nonprofit Markets: Evidence from County-Level Persistence and Relocation.
Under review, *Nonprofit Management and Leadership*
- [3] Combs, A., Foster, J.M., Troland, E. Is Assessment Regressivity Higher in Lower-Wealth Jurisdictions?
- [2] Combs, A. Fiscal Illusion Under the Cover of Property Tax Limits: School District Revenue Responses to a Reordering of Tax Levy Options.
- [1] Combs, A., & Kim, S. From Public Labels to Private Resources: The Nonprofit Revenue Response to School District Fiscal Distress Labels.

Conference Presentations

- [22] Should We Put Food Back on the Table? An Examination of Food in the Sales Tax Base. 2025
Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management
- [21] Sharing the Burden: Did Sales Tax Redistribution Alleviate Excess Property Taxes in North Carolina Counties? 2025
Association for Budgeting and Financial Management
- [20] Equity in Local Option Tax Policy: Rethinking What is Fair. 2024
Public Management Research Conference
- [19] Equity in Local Option Tax Policy: Rethinking What is Fair. 2024
Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management

[18] Dollars, Desks, and Development: The Impact of Local Sales Tax Revenue Redistribution on Recipient Programs in North Carolina. Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2024
[17] The impact of school district tax and expenditure limits on education-supporting nonprofit revenues. Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management	2023
[16] The impact of school district tax and expenditure limits on education-supporting nonprofit revenues. Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2023
[15] The impact of school district tax and expenditure limits on education-supporting nonprofit revenues. Southeastern Conference for Public Administration	2023
[14] School district TEL stringency and education-supporting nonprofit revenues: Crowding out community support to supplement school revenues. Korean Association of Public Administration	2023
[13] School district TEL stringency and the finances of education-supporting nonprofits: Crowding out community support to supplement school revenues. Association of Education Finance and Policy	2023
[12] Do nonprofits substitute educational resources in response to tax and expenditure limits on school districts? Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2022
[11] Property tax levies relative to predetermined options: Exploiting fiscal illusion? Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management	2022
[10] The effects of removing voter recall from school district property taxes. Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2021
[9] The impact of state oversight on property assessments and school district revenues. Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management	2019
[8] The effects of homestead exemptions for the disabled and the elderly on school districts. Association of Education Finance and Policy	2019
[7] High-tuition, high-aid policy and college expenditures. Association of Education Finance and Policy	2018
[6] Are state subsidies in higher education driving a divergence in institutional expenditures? Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2018
[5] The effect of NCLB waivers on college outcomes. Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management	2017
[4] Local response to school finance equalization: The importance of place. Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management	2017

[3] Local response to school finance equalization. Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2017
[2] The effect of distance on degree completion. Association of Education Finance and Policy	2016
[1] Trends and determinants of state government privatization activity. Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2015

Research Assistance

Visiting Research Assistant, Kentucky Center for Statistics	2018-2019
Research Fellow, Council of State Governments	2013-2014

Awards & Fellowships

UGA Active Learning Summer Institute Fellow	2025
Best Field Note of the Year in <i>State and Local Government Review</i>	2024
UGA Student Career Success Influence Award	2024
Busbee Endowment Seed Grant (\$13,200)	2021
Graduate School Academic Year Fellowship, University of Kentucky	2016
Graduate School Academic Year Fellowship, University of Kentucky	2015
Daniel Reedy Award for Outstanding MPA Thesis, University of Kentucky	2014

Teaching

University of Georgia

Data Applications in Public Administration	Fall 2019-Spring 2025; Spring 2026
Education Finance and Policy	Fall 2022
Introduction to the Nonprofit Sector	Fall 2020; Fall 2025; Spring 2026
Introduction to Public Policy Analysis	Spring of 2020, 2022, 2023, and 2024
Public Financial Management	Fall of 2019, 2021, 2023, and 2025
Faculty-Mentored Undergraduate Research I	Summer 2022

University of Kentucky

Public Program Evaluation	Spring 2019
Strategic Planning & Organizational Change	Fall 2018
Economic and Business Statistics	Spring 2017
Education: Economics and Policy (TA)	Fall 2015

Service

Students

Youkyoung Jeong, Public Administration (Ph.D.), University of Georgia, 2023
Dissertation Committee Member

Conferences

Panel Chair, Association for Budgeting and Financial Management 2026
Panel Chair, Association for Budgeting and Financial Management 2025
Panel Chair, Public Management and Research Conference 2024
Panel Chair, Southeastern Conference for Public Administration. 2023
Panel Discussant, Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management. 2022

Department, School, & University

Faculty Executive Committee, 2024
Department of Public Administration & Policy
College Curriculum Committee, 2020; 2023-Present
School of Public and International Affairs

Reviewer for Journals and Presses

Public Budgeting & Finance; Public Finance and Management; State and Local Government Review; Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis; AERA Open; Educational Researcher; Routledge; Journal of Postsecondary Student Success; Journal of Infrastructure, Policy and Development;

Media Commentary

Perez, I. (2026, Aug. 3). Northwest Georgia Counties Assess Budgets in Light of New Tax Exemptions. *Chattanooga Times Free Press*.
Coughlin, L. (2025, Aug. 29) Oconee County Local Option Sales Tax Election Primer. *Grady New-source*
Kiernan, J.S. (2023, Feb. 21) Property Taxes by State. *WalletHub*.
Kiernan, J.S. (2021, March 17) Most & Least Federally Dependent States. *WalletHub*.

Non-Academic Employment

Associate Director of Leadership Development, Sigma Nu Fraternity Inc. 2010-2013
Leadership Consultant, Sigma Nu Fraternity Inc. 2009-2010